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Bobby Shew

First call trumpeter Bobby Shew played an important role in numerous big bands, countless studio sessions, and has also excelled as a jazz soloist and music educator.

Bobby was interviewed via Zoom on December 1, 2020, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for a re-visit with Bobby Shew. I should tell our listeners that we had an earlier gathering and the tech spirits were not with us, or they were with us, I'm not sure which. So we'll see how it goes today. So I wanted to start out with a quote from a wise man, who said regarding jazz playing, "the ultimate goal is to play by ear and feel. Human spirit and emotion needs to be free to express itself.

BS: Who said that?

MR: You did.

BS: Oh did I?

MR: Yeah.

BS: I was going to say it sounds exactly like something I would say. I get so perturbed sometimes you know, and you know I guess I probably, I don't mean to be an elitist or anything about this music, but I care more about this music than I could even, you know, with all the dictionaries that I own and everything I don't think I could come up with the words to express my, the depth of my emotional feelings for this music. It's not just music to me, it's something greater than that. It's religion, it's philosophy, it's a way of life, it's the connection to the full meaning of my life ever since I was, when I found out about improvisation it wasn't — I always liked music as a kid you know, and my parents, and my grandmother and my mom played the old 78 albums and things like that, it was mostly Guy Lombardo and Wayne King, there was one Harry James 78 there you know. But I had no clue who Harry James was.

MR: Right. You didn't think of this is like really sweet stuff.

BS: No. No I was just — it was music, they loved music and they played music in the house fairly regularly. I mean one of the big things that I always recalled was on Sunday nights that I remember, as best I remember it, there was a thing called the Bell Telephone Hour I believe. And if I'm not mistaken I think it was the New York Philharmonic or something like that that played. It was a New York symphony orchestra. And my grandmother and my mom, they liked Mario Lanza, the Great Caruso, things like that. They liked the opera kind of thing you know. And so they would listen to classical music on Sunday and we would like, well I was probably no more than a year and a half or something, old, I was

laying on a little blanket in a diaper you know. But we listened to that music, and I had an uncle, Tom, who also loved classical music. So we'd gather around in the living room and listen to this thing every Sunday night. And I just remember laying there and listening. But the first one that hit me like a bong in the head was when they did "Peter and the Wolf." I was probably maybe about two or two and a half years old when I heard that. And a bassoon could be a duck? I thought wow that is the hippest thing in the world you know. Or whatever. The instruments could become animals. And suddenly there was this whole kind of thing happened in my head, it added meaning to it — it wasn't just sounds it had visual characteristics, characters and a story line and everything you know. For whatever reason I really, to this very day, I can almost go back to that moment on the floor and remember that. That's weird.

MR: I had an experience like that at Boy Scout camp with a visiting troop and some song they did with rhythms that I'd never heard before. And I was wondering if you've ever had a student who could play technically really well but just seemed devoid of what you're describing, that the music had no depth or emotion behind it.

BS: Well I don't think there's enough paper on this planet to make a list of those people who I've run across in my life. It's like the most common thing that you see, and it's one of the kind of little personal gripes that I rabble rouse about in the field of education in the fact that it's all become too greatly influenced, and I think from the books, some of the books that I've read, try to go back in history several hundred years where it became like a difficult situation for court trumpeters say for instance. If you have to do a fanfare if a visiting king and queen came in and if your chops were not in good shape and you clammed a few, like smear a couple of them on the wall, the castle wall — I read a thing in an ITG thing years and years ago where they, some research they actually decapitated a court trumpeter some times if they did a poor performance. So when you go back four, five, six hundred years you know, in Medieval times and stuff, well and who was making, there was not even a trumpet, it was they ripped a horn off of a rhinoceros or something. You know? And blew on an animal horn. And I mean and even when they started making instruments out of metal and things, it was the blacksmith when he finished with a set of horseshoes he'd make you a trumpet or a mouthpiece or something. So I mean the quality wasn't there and I mean could you imagine I mean for a trumpet player to pick up a piece of garbage that was made by a blacksmith in between a couple of horses, you know, I mean I don't think you're going to work Carnegie Hall on that you know. And so the point being that this whole history of fear of making a mistake, this right and wrong issue, which — it's something aside from music. It's deeply embedded in the subconscious mind in the genomes of humanity of civilization, every person on the planet goes back far enough in civilization we try to survive. It's a pro and con of

survival. The issue of right and wrong is like a gigantic social button that can get pushed and what happens is it stimulates — I mean I'm not a great psychologist but I took two years of psychology in high school 'cause I couldn't get into the class I wanted. It turned out to be the best mistake I ever made was to study psychology. And when I got into college I signed up for it again because I said I've gotta keep studying this stuff. And there's this thing, it stimulates like the amygdala part of the brain which is the fear factor thing.

MR: You had shared a little lesson that I'd like to hear about again, and that was getting your students to play an F scale —

BS: Oh yeah. Well the thing is, here's the bottom line for me and what I was delving into, and I'm sorry you'd know that I kissed the Blarney stone at one time you know, I have this gabbing kind of gift that I keep going. But I take these asides in conversation quite often. But the thing about it that I was getting at is that music is basically an emotional thing. It's not supposed to be just a clinical, don't-miss-a-note kind of thing. And that's what's happened to music education over the years to a point where you know you sit in and — you take a lesson. What are you doing? The guy makes you play a page until you don't miss a note on it. Well you miss the whole point of why are you playing it, where's the emotion? Where's the joy? Where's the humanity of this, the real meaning behind music. You know? It's not even there. And most of the teachers are not even aware of it because it's like the contagion of aberration they call it, it's one generation after another keep passing on, you know, kind of an attitude about music and you get into a concert band and the band director's just, oh we'll play this until we don't miss any notes. Then you get in an orchestra and how uptight is that? A guy like Ozawa in front of an orchestra for Christ's sake, everybody's like dropping Valiums every ten minutes, you notice that?

MR: Yes. I've often wondered why nobody in an orchestra seems to ever smile.

BS: Yeah. Hell no, their life is on the line at all times. You know I've known, I won't mention any names here because I love them, but I know some very prominent orchestral people, not only trumpet players but others too, that live and die by that sword. They sit there and they're in constant sweating. And especially if it's a long period where they can't play for — they've got tacet sheets and they've got to wait out for 400 measures during the violin solo or something, and then you've got to suddenly come in and it's marcato and it's [scats] and you've got to come in and hit a high D or something, and you sit there and you start worrying about that. The future is like looming at you and it's like dragons on your shoulders and stuff, you know. And then you look and there's Ozawa up there glaring at everybody, and oh for Christ's sake you know. But I swear to you, but the whole point about it is that when I teach, when I teach [gestures quotes] I use quotes around that word because I don't really, I just try to inspire more than anything. But the

whole idea is I try to make sure that people understand the value of playing everything with some emotion in it. That little example, I think the story that you are referring to is it's just a little maked up game I play when I do a lecture on improvisation is the thing. But it's not only about improvisation, it's just picking up the horn and playing period. But it is that you know you can pretend, I take three emotions: sorrow, angry and happy. And I have them play the scale like sorrowfully. And I say pretend that the neighbor ran over your cat you know and oh my God I love that cat. Get that emotion going, and I love that cat. Now play that scale thinking about your favorite cat and try to make sure that the way you approach that scale, it's not like [scats] that's not sorrowful. Emotion has to do with a vibration in the body and everything. And you get down into sorrow and apathy and things like that, it goes very slow. Whereas if you're angry, if you say that neighbor I'm going to kill him, he drives like an idiot, I'm gonna — he ran over my cat I'm going to kill him. Now play that scale [scats]. Baseball bat to the head. Okay? And then you say wait a minute, that's not my cat, and now you play happy [scats]. And so just as it's a silly example but it gets the point across very easily not only to children but to adults as well who sit there and say God what have I been doing all these years?

MR: Yeah.

BS: You know you open up the Arban book and you play scales and stuff, all you're doing is trying to accumulate huge amounts of technical facility in hopes, and when your attention is on you in the practice room, what is your goal? Damn I hope I don't miss any notes here today. You know?

MR: Did you have, with the big bands you played with which included Woody Herman and Goodman and Toshiko and Louie Bellson, did they have — did any of them have leadership qualities that you either resented or admired?

BS: Yes.

MR: Okay you don't get away with just a yes now.

BS: Yeah all of them had — I think the biggest idiot that I ever worked for and one of the most difficult people, and I'm not the only person who would tell you this, this has been written up in books, was Benny Goodman. He was an extremely difficult person, I think even his daughter I remember in an interview, never understood her father. He was like I don't know, in those days we didn't know what the term "bipolar" meant you know. It was not a term that was around. I would guess almost that Benny had some bipolar things or some schizophrenia thing. Because you could never quite figure out why he had to be so nasty and so mean and so condescending to people. Like when people had words with him he was racist — I remember Buddy Tate, one time when Buddy Tate was on the band and I was there and he sent Buddy out like he was like a slave. He sent him out, he called him "boy" all the time and it was like embarrassing. You know? It was like I mean

Buddy was such a — nicest cat in the world and a great player. Why is Benny treating him like that? I thought God this is insane.

MR: You know Joe Wilder would not even say his name.

BS: Oh that's right. I remember Joe talking about Benny you know. I think the thing with Benny was I don't really know if Benny even had a clue to himself. I really don't know. He was such a brilliant player, I mean, what a great clarinet player, absolutely you know. But I swear when I was on the band I was on there twice. And the first time it was his band and I was hired in the section and Wes Hensel was hired as the lead player. Wes was the great lead player with Les Brown's band for many years back in the 40s and all that stuff you know. And Wes was a great trumpet player. He was not a jazz player but he was a great arranger and everything. But we were at the first rehearsal and Benny kept staring at the trumpet section. And we're playing you know. And he's just staring at the trumpet section. And I'm going like what the hell is going on with this guy. And I was very young and you know, kind of like green and didn't know what was going on. I was thrilled to be with Benny Goodman but you know, and the band was like it was an all-star band, Georgie Auld was on the band, and Lou Levy was the piano player. Colin Bailey on drums, Monty Budwig on bass. Are you kidding me? And I mean Carl Fontana was on the band, Jimmy Gwynn I mean come on give me a break. I mean look who's in this band you know? And, but he kept staring at the trumpet section. After a while he called a break. And this guy, I think his name was Larry Grayson, he was kind of Benny's manager. He came over and we were kind of just standing around and he came over to me and he said, "Bobby I need to talk to you." And I went oh boy, here I go, I said, "Look, Larry, I mean it must be something about me he doesn't like. But it's okay, I'm just going, you don't have to patronize me I'm out of here." He says, "Oh no, no, no, no, Benny wants you on lead." So I went, "What?" He said, "He wants you on lead, he doesn't like the way Wes is playing lead." He moved Wes Hensel to fourth chair, put me on all the lead, Jack Sheldon was sitting next to me in the trumpet section, and Carl Saunders was in the section. And I had to play all the lead and all of the solos. He wouldn't let Jack Sheldon play any solos. I had to memorize all of the Harry James' things on all of those pieces, and go out front, memorized, and play them. And it was like unbelievable. And I thought damn. Right? You mean like now? Right now? And then here's the other funny thing was Jack was like the comedian. He would go out front and do a little ten minutes of comedy. And when he did that Benny would come back in the session and sit in Jack's chair. And Jack had some charts so we'd play, back him up while he sang you know? And Benny would sit right to my left and turn like this and stare at me. Like his face is twelve inches away from my face and I'm trying to play and

Benny's sitting there looking at me like, staring at me. I'm going holy crap, you want to talk about a heartbeat. My pulse was about 500.

MR: Oh well I'm sure he gave you a big raise for all that double duty.

BS: No. Nothing. And he never said one complimentary word to me, not once ever. Not once ever. And it was just, we did four weeks at the Tropicana Hotel with that band. And it was — we had, who else did we have on there, oh we had Mavis Rivers is the singer. Remember her?

MR: I do not.

BS: Oh yes she was a great singer. She's from Samoa. Yeah. You know Matt Catingub the saxophone player?

MR: No.

BS: Oh you should know him. That's his mom. She's his mom. Matt is a brilliant young saxophone player. He lives in Vegas, and a writer and all of that. He was on Louie Bellson's band and all of that. Anyway, so Benny was the worst of them. You know Woody Herman was cool except that Woody could be really icy cold at times you know, and you know I've seen him downgrade Sal Nestico when we were on the band together. And Nat Pierce wrote a ballad for Sal, "Easy Living" I think it was, and Woody wouldn't let him play it. He wanted Sal to always do that fast [scats] machine gun stuff. And Sal wanted to play a ballad and Woody wouldn't let him you know. Woody was like, he could be cruel. You know. But then one of the nicest guys I ever worked for was Si Zentner actually you know. Just a general warm guy, friendly, cool, positive, encouraging at all times. Terry Gibbs was a lot of fun to work for you know. Terry had a few quirks here and there once in a while that you know he would get a hair up his butt and scream about something that was totally not worth screaming about you know. But you know, and then the other guy that I — Buddy Rich of course, who I worked for, was one of the greatest experiences musically that I ever had but one of the most intense emotional kind of nervous kind of things. Well you know the stories about Buddy you know, and talk about bipolar, there's another one too you know. And you know Buddy was like, Buddy and I he loved me, and the greatest compliment that I ever got in my entire career came indirectly from Buddy, through his wife. My wife and Marie Rich were good friends before I met my wife actually. Because my wife was a dancer in Vegas and she used to dance in a show opposite the Harry James band when Buddy was on Harry's band. And so we used to, after I left Buddy's band, Marie and my wife and I we used to go out and go to dinner sometimes together. And so the story that Marie said to me, she said, "Buddy was on a break and he was home and she came to him in the living room and said 'Oh I saw Bobby and Lisa Shew today, and they said to say hello to you.'" And Buddy did the four letter word Bobby Shew you know. And she said, "Why do you hate him so

much?" He said, "Because I've never been able to replace him." And she told me that and I went — wow you couldn't pat me on the back any further than that you know. What a compliment from Buddy.

MR: Indeed. Those were some great records.

BS: That was years after I had left the band. And he had probably gone through another ten lead players trying to find one. But see I grew up playing drums when I was 14 and so Buddy could hear something about me knowing the drums in my playing.

MR: I see. Did you experience like some of those long road trips on the buses?

BS: Oh boy did we ever.

MR: How did you — did you have any ways of dealing with that?

BS: Well I was enjoying what I was doing. I was in my early 20s and spunky you know. And unfortunately there was a lot of drugs in those days and I was doing some of them, so that kept us, that was a focus point for a lot of the guys in Buddy's band, where half of the band were using some hard drugs and so forth. Gene Quill was playing lead alto. Pete Yellin, Jay Cory, Marty Flax, Steve Perlow were the saxophone section you know? And all five of those guys were using hard drugs plus myself and the bass player and some of the other guys were just smoking weed and stuff. But that's part of the whole thing in those days. I mean I wouldn't touch any of those things now for a truckload of hundred dollar bills you know? I cleaned up way over fifty years ago because I knew, I suddenly realized if I was going to play the horn to my best level I didn't need to be all screwed up on hard core drugs. You know? I mean you can fool yourself saying, "Yeah man, me and Bird we're into it right now." No you're not. But the good thing was I never had any real serious problems with it. I never had any legal issues, no police issues, I never got busted or anything. I mean I got out of it wisely, in time you know. But I'll tell you what, Woody Herman's band, sometimes we would do like, we would do like almost about three months without hardly ever a night off. You know? I mean you'd get one night off once in a while but it would always be in some horrible place out in the middle of nowhere you didn't want to be. You know. Who wants a night off in LeMars, Iowa?

MR: Yeah and there was a lot less ways to distract yourself pre cell phone and all that stuff.

BS: Oh yeah.

MR: Yeah, when you entered the studio scene, was it mostly by recommendation that you get into that?

BS: The way it happened was quite unusual in that when Buddy Rich's band played and we recorded the "West Side Story" thing at the Shea and in L.A., we were there for four weeks and when we had every night, every show was sold out. Every show for four weeks. I mean it was never empty. And it was movie stars. You'd look out there and there's Judy Garland. She'd come and sit in with the band. Johnny Carson would sit in

and play a tune with the band. Milton Berle is right there you know. All of the movie stars. Edie Adams bought the whole club out one night for her personal friends. And you'd look and it was just like you were in the movies, you see all of these movie stars in the place you know. But what happened was Terry Gibbs came in several times, 'cause of course he loved Buddy and all of that. And Terry liked the way I played lead trumpet. And he always remembered it. And Al Porcino was his lead player in those days, and Al was in there. That's when I first met Al. And Al would come back stage and hand me a pipe full of weed, you know, "Nice set, you know, kiddo." But anyway Terry, the story is that I was living in Vegas back in those days. And Terry, and they were doing a show called "Operation Entertainment" which was like a USO entertainment show. It was Chuck Barris production.

MR: Oh yeah. "The Gong Show."

BS: "The Gong Show," guy, yeah. But he produced this show called "Operation Entertainment." It was really great. And we'd go out every, for ten days every month and they did the pilot show in San Diego on an aircraft carrier. And Al was still using drugs in those days and he nodded on the show. And they had to let him go. And so Al Porcino, one of the greatest lead trumpet players of all time and certainly a big influence on me you know. But the thing about it was when they let Al go, Terry, instead of calling one of the other guys in L.A. he thought I'm going to call that Bobby Shew guy and see if he'll do these shows. So he called me up in Vegas and he said, "Can you come down to L.A. and do these?" And they would go to Ventura and do like the Navy base or this and that around. Then they started getting on planes and flying to Maxwell Air Force Base in Alabama, and all kinds of placed around the country. You know? But so I'd drive my Porsche down to L.A. and park it at the airport and get on the plane with them and we'd go all over the place. And so I took Al's place with the thing. And that's how, because all of a sudden it's an L.A. band but there's this Vegas trumpet player playing lead you know, and all of the guys, there was Med Flory was playing lead alto you know, and Frank Capp was the drummer and whatever. You know. So all these guys, Dalton Smith, Nick Morris, Don Rader was in the section and Slyde Hyde and Charlie Loper, and all of the top guys in L.A. And they're all saying Jeez, who is this guy you know? And then right, not much after that, my wife and I just got sick and tired of doing all the Jimmy Durante and Abbe Lane shows in Vegas and we decided to move to L.A. and take on something different. And as soon as I got in there I went in to hear Louie Bellson's band after one of the first nights and I just ran into Louie and Louie said, "What are you doing here?" And I said, "Well we moved here." He said, "You working tomorrow?"

MR: I love that.

BS: And then Chuck Findley was in the trumpet section and he — and Chuck — I had gotten Chuck on Buddy Rich's band when he was just out of high school. And so Chuck said, "Bobby, what are you doing? Are you going to stay here?" "Yeah, we moved here." He says, "Well man I've got a bunch of dates I need you on." All of a sudden Chuck was double booked and he was sending me in to cover for him on things and I'd show up, I was doing, like within two weeks in L.A. I was like doing a session or two almost every day. I was suddenly busy. And guys would look at me and go didn't you just move to town? How are you so busy all of a sudden you know? I said, "The phone just keeps ringing."

MR: You should have just said, "Well it's talent man, come on."

BS: Yeah. No I wouldn't do that. No the thing was they'd got me in and people like Chuck and then John Audino and Ray Triscari, all these guys had known me through Buddy's band and through Woody's band and through things like that, they knew who I was. And so they said, "Hell yes." And the contractors said okay. And of course when you show up you've got to play and I could read really well and I had decent chops. I had limitations but I didn't let anybody know what they were you know.

MR: I wonder if you could get real specific for me, because I've been curious about — you show up, first of all you get a call from the contractor, and they tell you the studio and the time. Do you get any other information like make sure you have your mutes? Bring your flugelhorn? Or are you just expected to know that part of it?

BS: Part of it you're expected to always have your mutes with you.

MR: Yeah.

BS: A flugelhorn, not necessarily, or a piccolo trumpet, or anything they're called doubles as you know, if the contractor calls you and says, "Bring a flugelhorn, they have to pay you for it whether you play it or not." Okay? So if the call is out for the doubles, you know, when I was working at Universal there was a lady there by the name of Sandy DeCrescent who was not a musician at all, she was the secretary to the guy that was the contractor and he committed suicide. And so the union people, mostly the string players and French horn players, you know typically, they thought let's vote to have Sandy be the contractor. See you have to be a musician in the musicians' union to be a contractor. And she wasn't. She was a secretary. But they thought well let's make her a musician. So they made her a maraca player. And they paid for her to join thinking that because they were on the list from the previous contractor that she would call them. Well she didn't. She started calling different people. And it all backfired on them. But Sandy became the Universal Studios contractor for years. And she was a pain in the ass. She didn't know nothing. So I got calls from her and told me to remind me to bring my flute and clarinet. She didn't know. And I'd go there and I'd say, you know you used to fill out the W9 and

all that and you think like should I put flute and clarinet on there and make her pay for this you know? And I was like no, I'm not going to do it.

MR: Well when you went in, you'd go in and you'd sit down in the chair and someone would pass out the music. Did you have a routine — let me start again — I try to tell my students when they get a piece of music, you know normally what younger people do is they get a piece of music and they immediately start going [scats] they look at one measure and they try to play it or something. And I'm wondering what did you guys do to give yourself the best chance to play it and not become a two-take player.

BS: Well I guess everybody has their own approach to that. A lot of it has to do with your attitude with you, if you feel confident in your sight reading skills, which I was always very good at, you know, I never had to worry, I could pretty much sight read. The only things I ever had any real complicated times with sight reading were during the disco period, when everything was all sixteenth notes [scats] damn it, how many sixteenth rests are there in this measure you know? And you'd have to sit there and visually like uhh — you know you get the point. Those were difficult. But there's a way to solve it, you make an imaginary line, if it's a 4/4 bar, down the middle of the bar and you start isolating where the one and the two and the three and the four are in the beat, in the measure. And once you see that then you can place those rest kind of things — because they were writing everything like instead of eighth notes, sixteenths and stuff like that a lot. And someone would start writing a sixteenth note and then two sixteenth rests and then another sixteenth. Holy crap that's only two beats you know? Or it's one beat. Or wait a minute, how many is that?

MR: It almost sounds like — it sounds like they were trying to orchestrate what a guitar does, a rhythm guitar, like [scats].

BS: And the drums, and the percussion. It's like all of that music was mostly percussive music. It's not very melodic. It's all rhythmic for the most part you know. And I don't remember any disco tune that had a melody I wanted to sing back — you know come home and sing this to my wife, oh wait 'til you hear this disco song I recorded today. It was like [scats percussively].

MR: Well you just anticipated a question I have right in front of me. You can't see it, but the question was what kind of thing would happen on a studio date that you would come home and it was interesting enough to tell your wife about?

BS: Hardly ever. Almost never. My wife could look at my face, the wrinkles in my face and tell whether I enjoyed myself or not. And she could tell. She said, "Another one, ey?" But I wanted to back up a little bit, Monk, if you don't mind, just because there's a thing about in the studio thing, it's a very, you know I mean what I had to do, what I did was different than what you were talking about the student who sings the two measure phrase.

The first thing, there's a way of prioritizing the way you look at a piece of music. You're only going to see it one time, you're never going to see it again ever in your life probably, ever. You know? If you're lucky. And the thing about it is the first thing you want to look at is, and a lot of people will say, "Look at the key signature first. Second, look at the key signature." But look at the first thing is the tempo. Find out how fast this thing is going to go first. Because if you look down and see five sharps you go oh my God. And then it says "largo" ahh I'm cool. You follow what I'm saying?

MR: I do indeed.

BS: Like you have to know the right priorities in order to salvage yourself spiritually in a situation like that because you can psychologically turn yourself into a banana pie if you don't watch out, real quick. So like you look at the tempo, then look at the key signature, then look at the roadmap. Where are the endings? Is there a coda? Where is the coda sign? Where does it go to? Where are the repeats? Like know the roadmap, where you're going to get in, where you've got to go back to if at all. Then you start looking in at where you see a lot of tricky measures, where you see a lot of notes in a measure. Then, that — if you look at that first you don't even know what tempo it's got to be in. And you haven't got the key signature sorted. And the priorities — at least in my opinion, were tempo, key signature, roadmap. That's first and foremost. And then start looking at the notes and see if there's anything that looks a little scary: high, lots of ledger lines, or lots of sixteenth notes in a measure, or a lot of funny kind of things. But if you prioritize it you save yourself an awful lot of stress by doing it that way you know. And the problems with being in a studio is when the contractor or the service, when the answering service calls you and books you on a studio and a time, sometimes they'll tell you who the writer is and sometimes they don't. If they say Bernard Herrmann, you go ohhhh shit. Take the Valium with me you know. Put a pint of whiskey in my horn case. Because Bernard Herrmann's going to be a pain in the ass. He's going to be — he's like Hitler you know? Real militant and screaming and hollering and things like that. If it's Jerry Goldsmith it's going to be much more relaxed. If it's Johnny Mandel it's going to be different. And you get to where you know these people, these writers, and some of them, like Peter Matz who I did an awful lot of stuff with Peter Matz, he was Barbra Streisand's conductor when I worked with her an awful lot. And Peter was like the writer on the "Carol Burnett Show" you know, the director and all that. I didn't do the "Carol Burnett Show" but we did Tony Orlando and Dawn right across the hall from them, but I got to know Peter really well. And Peter'd come up and he'd hug you and everything, "Yeah, Bobby." You know you could go up to some of the other ones and they didn't even know your name even after you'd done a hundred sessions with them you know.

MR: Were the writers and arrangers always at the sessions?

BS: Kind of yes more so than not. Sometimes, like for instance I did the "Tony Randall Show" and the main writer was Pat Williams. But Pat wrote the theme song and then he would farm out to ghost writing with Sammy Nestico. And Sammy Nestico was the writer, the ghost writer for everybody out there. He and Billy Byers. Billy Byers was one of the most insane, greatest skilled writers I think I've ever seen in my life. Billy could sit and write a chart without a score, put it in his head, and he'd come back in 45 minutes and have a thing for you done. Billy was unbelievable. And Billy did stuff for Nelson Riddle and all these people you know. A lot of people out there got a lot of credit for shit they didn't do, but when we did the "Tony Randall Show" Sammy was always there, because he did all of the inside charts, the little bumper things. You know when you're doing television you do like an opening theme. At maximum it's a minute and a half long or two minutes long. And then the closing theme where they put all the credits, that's another minute and a half. You don't play anything long. It's all seven second, five second bumpers, scene changes you know[scats] that's it. And you'd better be able to do that in one take because they don't want to do those like seven times.

MR: Yeah right. I imagine you did your share of rock & roll dates?

BS: I did yeah. I played a lot of gigs because TV doesn't pay anything.

MR: No kidding?

BS: There's no royalties in television. If I had, the shows that I did, like "Love Boat," "Hawaii 5-0," "Eight is Enough," "Mork & Mindy," the list goes on you would not believe it you know, if you saw the list of shows that I did. "Mission Impossible," whatever. The list is ridiculous. And there's no royalties paid on TV for musicians. Everybody else gets paid: the producers, the guy that mops the floor and goes out for sandwiches gets paid. But there was a problem going on with the AF of M years and years and years ago with negotiations for re — new contracts and they just didn't want to pay the increase in salaries and health & welfare and pension funds and stuff like that. So they argued and argued and argued and took it to court and the musicians lost. And we formed a thing called the Overseas TV Reports and all that would try to get — but I can go to like Tanganyika and turn on TV and see "Love Boat" with me playing it, and in another language. And everybody's getting paid, all of the actors are getting paid, the producers, but I'm not getting paid. And that is a horrible thing for the musicians. But I did an awful lot — a fair amount of rock & roll things you know. I did — well I recorded stuff with Elvis, I recorded with Neil Diamond, I did things with the Tubes you know.

MR: Oh the Tubes.

BS: Well whatever, yeah, and Willie Nelson and people like that you know. And the good thing is when you record for recording, for LPs and CDs and stuff like that, you get royalties. You know you get AFM royalties. So I'm at this point, having retired now, I do

get royalty payments for the things that I get for rock & roll records and all of the motion picture soundtracks that I did which was probably about a hundred and some movie soundtracks.

MR: Were those rock & roll dates different? Did you ever show up to do a date and there was no music? Like you were expected to come up with horn parts?

BS: Boy did I ever. Yeah. A lot of them were like that. And there was this one guy, what the hell was his name, I've suppressed his name purposely I guess. But I would show up, myself and the saxophone player would show up and they'd have all these rhythm tracks and you'd start listening to them. And then, "What do you guys feel? What do you feel? What do you feel?" You know? You'd have to sit there and, "How about this?" [scats] Oh yeah I like that, I like that. So we're looking at each other and going let's get this thing done and get the hell out of here.

MR: Yeah, I've had that experience. I wonder if when you had to do that, was there a vocal you were hearing?

BS: Sometimes, yeah.

MR: Because you don't want to be —

BS: You don't want to get in the way.

MR: Yeah you don't want to be getting in the way, right.

BS: Well the other thing is I did one time for this one guy and — I can't remember his name but he was a noteworthy producer out there, a rock & roll guy. And those people I did not enjoy working with very much. But this guy, he heard that I played trombone also. So I had to bring my trombone in there and my trumpet, and a flugelhorn. And when I got in there there was nothing but a track. And so we'd figure out, and I'd have to figure it all out by my ear. And I'd sing it to him and I'd put my horn or I'd put a mute in and I'd play along with the track in the booth and he'd say yeah that's good right there, I like that, that's good. No let's leave that open right there. And I'd go through it a few times and I'm trying to remember what the hell did I do you know. And you have to go in there, but the good thing about that is that they stop the tape and they can go back and keep punching in and punch out. So one track would take a whole afternoon, like four hours or five hours. Because I would finally put the first trumpet part on the way we wanted it. Then I'd go back in and put a second trumpet part on, and maybe a third trumpet part on, and then I'd pick up the trombone and I'd put on three trombone parts. And I would build an entire brass section myself. The good news about that is for every person that I record for I have to get paid as an individual so I got paid six salaries for an afternoon. And one salary for a session would be say like $450 or $500 so you're making like three grand for an afternoon. You know.

MR: Well that helps. Even though you might have had wrinkles on your forehead —

BS: It pays for a lot of Aleves and Advils. But you know I have to tell you one time I was doing a thing at Universal and the trumpet section you know it's a funny thing that Dalton Smith, who was a great guy to play with and work with all the time, Stan Kenton's lead player for a while. But sometimes they used to write stuff so high and ridiculously hard for me, I'd finish it and I'd get it done but I'd go Christ why do they write like this for me and oh my God, you know? And Dalton said you know one time, he said, "There's an exercise that you can do," he said, "and if you do that exercise it saves your chops and you can last forever." And I said, "Really? I need to know what is that exercise?" He says, "Here, you play this and you play that."

MR: Oh that's a good one. You don't find — they don't teach you that in music school.

BS: No they don't. So I was doing a thing at Universal Studios one day and it was just sort of like a silly movie about like the late 20s or early 30s or something. And it was a scene where there was a little kind of a John Philip Sousa tiny band on a gazebo in a park and people were all walking through on a Sunday afternoon you know, and they're dressed up and all of that. And you turn the page and there's "Carnival of Venice." What? Why the writer had to put that there. He could have put anything there, but this was, somebody said, "Oh I'm going to put 'Carnival of Venice.'" So it's like you must hate trumpet players you know, to make, all of a sudden you turn the page and there's this thing. Well I couldn't play that thing ever in my life. Not now and not then. Because I never took any lessons as a kid, I never learned to double tongue or triple tongue. I had no classical training whatsoever you know, other than playing marches in my high school band, that was it. You know and other than that I was just a jazz guy and a big band person. So I played on some salsa bands but I couldn't double tongue. So you know I looked at that thing and there's Warren Luening sitting right next to me and I went, "You got it." And Warren had done all of that. He had done all that stuff and I just passed the part to him and he nailed it just like the old Del Staigers one. And it was not the entire thing but it was enough that I couldn't have played it, not in a million years. Well when we did the "Tony Randall Show" the theme, the first session is a piccolo trumpet. What the hell? Nelson Hatt. Here you go, Nelson. So you pass the part. Because you've got to keep — one of the things is that it's very important in those situations is you cannot go in there with an ego issue. You're asking for trouble if you do. Because ego is really simply defined as self-importance. When you're important and I have to do this, and I'm going to brag about 'cause I did this. Well you're going to shit all over that piccolo trumpet part and everybody on the planet is going to know who sucked on that piccolo thing on the "Tony Randall Show." "Oh that was Shew." I shoulda figured. But you should know when to say no. Shew passed the part to Nelson Hatt. Oh that Shew is a smart cookie. And so you've got to keep your ego completely out of the picture when you go into those

things. Sometimes, and I got caught one time on a film, a TV movie about some inconsequential invasion of bees in an Indiana small village. Who knew? It was not important but there was only one trumpet on the thing and I turned the page and there was a whole bunch of double tonguing. And I tried to do it and I really couldn't do it. I could not handle it. And I went oh, and you've got 30 seconds to get it ready. And so I did it one time and it was terrible. And the conductor goes, "Take two." Oh you want to hear that again? So I'm going, oh crap. So I couldn't do it. And he stopped and he looked at me and he said, "Is there a problem, sir?" And I said, me and my big mouth I had to say, "Man it's not my bag you dig?" and he threw the baton at me. And this was in front of like an 80 piece orchestra and I'm the only trumpet. And the contractor was Gus Klein who was Manny Klein's son. You know? And Gus is a good guy but Gus leans over and he says, "Bobby, what the hell are you doing?" I said, "What are you doing putting me on a session like this?" But he doesn't know, the contractor doesn't know what the music is. He just gets a call from the writer and he's not looking at the parts. He doesn't go through everybody's part and says oh we can't hire Bobby for this there's double tonguing on one page you know. So they hire you and you're expected to be able to be the most eclectic guy on the planet. You've got to walk in there and do everything. So what happened is I had to go out and talk to the guy and apologize and everything. And I said, "Look, I'm sorry, I don't mean to be — but it intimidated me when you throw a baton at me it doesn't make it easier." I says, "I'll go in there now and I'll figure out how to play this thing for you but if it requires that I pay for the entire orchestra for an extra hour I will pay it, ten thousand dollars, but I'm not going to take a baton in the face. Money is not that important to me, if that's what it's going to take." So I walked in there and I sat down and everybody was looking at me like ooh. And I walked over there and I looked at that thing and I thought how in the hell am I going to do this? And then I remembered when I got out of high school I went back to New York and I used to go out and listen to Kenny Dorham and Roy Eldridge and all these guys play. And they used to do, I used to watch Kenny Dorham and he used to do a thing with alternate fingerings. And he'd do things like this [plays his trumpet]. And I went damn, how's he do that? And I messed around and I went alternate fingerings. So I went in there and I put a mute in and I practiced this page using alternate fingerings until I could do it. And the guy came in and he looked at me and he said, "Are we ready?" And I went, "Yes sir, we are." And everybody in the orchestra went what? He learned to double tongue that fast you know? And I did it and the guy thought I double tongued it. He never knew that I was only using alternate fingerings like that. And on the trumpet there's a lot of 'em. And if you know 'em you can bullshit your way right through it. And I walked out of that studio that day like whew, oh God.

MR: Well you kind of said it earlier in the interview that you've got to keep your wits about you. And you know if you had like freaked out you probably wouldn't have had that memory of seeing those guys do that alternate fingering.

BS: Well yeah but I think the thing is you have to learn to think on your feet you know. And I mean I encourage the students that study with me now, especially if they're in school, I'm caught in between two realities on this. One of them is being eclectic and learning to play all styles while you're young. That means study classical music yes. Learn to double, triple tongue, yes. You know, learn to transpose, yes. If you have to play a C trumpet okay get one. Whatever. But become, you have to be prepared. And if you, you know a hundred percent doesn't exist. Perfect doesn't exist. But you walk into those situations out there in a studio and you're just like the utility guy. You walk in not knowing what you're going to run into and you have to just be ready for whatever can happen. And sometimes it just, like that situation with me with the alternate fingerings, whoo I don't know how I managed to come up with that but the fact that I did saved my ass and saved my career. I mean I could have been really, you know once they say, there's a funny little story I'll give ya. The musicians are talking to a contractor and they say to the contractor, "Have you heard this new guy in town, Bobby Shew?" "No I haven't heard him, no, no, never heard of him. What's his name, Bobby Shew?" "Yeah, yeah. Oh yeah he's quite a player. Yeah I was on a session with him last week and God he came in and sight read everything, he just played beautifully and lyrically and everything. And then I was on a session the next day and he was playing up in the upper register like Maynard, God I couldn't believe it, everybody was saying wow this guy, Bobby Shew." "What's his name, Bobby Shew?" "Yeah you've got to know him." No, the contractor had never heard of him, never heard of him. "And then a couple of days ago I was on a session and he chipped a high D." "Oh I did hear about that." You know and this is one of the things about the studio situation is that as long as you're okay, you're okay. But the minute you start chipping, the word's all over town in a minute. I mean word gets out. And it's so competitive, Monk, for every chair open for trumpet there's 300 guys sitting there wishing they were on it. You know? And there's a — all the contractors have priority lists. And sometimes some of the musicians, I won't say any names here but one of the reasons I quit the studio in 1982 is because there were a couple of musicians that came in that were trying to control who was being called on sessions. And this one guy for instance, he would get a call from the service said well you're such and such for such and such day and such and such hours. And he'd say, "Well who else is in the trumpet section?" "Well Bobby Shew and Dalton Smith." "Really? Tell the contractor put me on hold and tell the contractor to call me." So the contractor would call, "Is there an issue?" And he'd say, "Is it true that you really want Bobby Shew and Dalton

Smith on this session?" The contractor'd say, "Why is there a problem?" He'd say, "Well I don't want to say anything bad about those guys you know …" He's already said it. The contractor would say, "Well who do you want?" And he'd say well can you get my friend here and this other friend of mine. Because we went to school together, or we have the same teacher or something like that. And then Dalton Smith and Bobby Shew are getting a cancellation you see. And this kind of stuff happens and you get a couple of egomaniacal idiots who start to try to manipulate other people's right to put beans and rice on the table and provide new shoes for their kids. And we're all in this thing together. Back in the early days, when I first started doing sessions it was a really good brotherhood. People — this one guy would be sick, his wife would be sick, we'd all throw in dates just so he could make some money to help pay for the medical bills or something. And everybody was a brotherhood to try to look out for each other and nobody would ever backstab anybody. But it was like the rock & rollers that got into it, those kind of guys got a different attitude you know. I think when we started this conversation we were talking about the emotional relationship with the music, the human part of this whole thing. And when you get into it when it's only a money thing and it's only an ego thing and only, hey you see I'm on this record, I'm on that record, do you see that's me playing this, that's me playing that you know. And you get into all of that the whole thing, the game changes. And it becomes like you know you've got to keep your back to the wall. There were certain people you just don't want to be around. And that's a sad thing. It's a real horrible thing. But I think why, in my opinion for whatever that's worth, I think an awful lot of this goes back to what I was saying to you about the problems in the educational system is they make it more and more and more about the perfection — don't miss any notes kind of thing, and they change the priorities around so it's all about ego and money and not missing any notes, and see how high I can play. And I hear guys now and I heard a video just two or three hours ago, somebody sent me a video of a trumpet player, a young trumpet player and I listened to him, God he's got fingers and chops like you can't believe. But it makes absolutely no sense whatsoever. It's like, it's like a million notes for what reason. And it reminded me of a lecture that I have on cassette. It's an interview with Coleman Hawkins, and, by an English guy when Coleman was over in Britain and this guy interviewed him. And Coleman says on the cassette, he says, "You know I spent my entire life trying to figure out what not to play." And it's kind of like as you grow older and so forth you start to — I go back and listen to things I recorded thirty or forty years ago and I'm thinking oh God what was I thinking you know. Yeah, too many notes.

MR: Well Bobby, this has been great. I'm so glad that you could get together with me this afternoon. And I'm going to wrap up by testing your memory.

BS: Okay.

MR: At the age of twelve I believe you broke your piggy bank so you could buy three records. And do you remember what those three records were?

BS: Dave Brubeck's first album on Fantasy Records, "Stan Getz with Strings," and a J.J. Johnson album.

MR: Yes indeed.

BS: I was so blown away. And I never heard a trumpet player yet, not a jazz player. Well I had heard Harry James on a 78 but not realizing you know. But the first jazz trumpet player I heard was Don Fagerquist with the Les Brown band. And I went uh — what the heck is that? You know? And then I started buying all the Les Brown albums so I could listen to Don. And then years later when he was with the Dave Pell Octet I bought all of those. And then after Don had passed away, Dave called me up. I took Don's chair in the Dave Pell Octet.

MR: That's great. Well after we're done here I want you to go back and see if those three records are still in your 3,000 LP collection.

BS: They are.

MR: Okay.

BS: And there's a guy coming here from New York in about a week and a half and he's going to go through them and pick out some collectables and buy them from me. I've got — I don't listen to that much vinyl anymore because a lot of those things I've got replaced onto CD now and so it's easier to pull out a CD and I don't climb a ladder very well and most of them are way over there in that high corner over there. But anyway it's always great, man, thank you so much. I'm so flattered that you contacted me for these things. You know I've watched several of your other interviews, I've gone onto the link and gone out there and listened to them. I started with both of Denis DiBlasio's and I started going from there. There's some very very interesting conversations you've had.

MR: I'm going to recommend one for you.

BS: Okay go.

MR: Gerald Wilson and Snooky Young sitting together.

BS: I've seen it. Yeah.

MR: That was a thrill.

BS: Well for me, I was on Gerald's band playing the lead chair for a while, and then Snooky Young stood next to me on Louie Bellson's band for a long time and he was also, we were in Bill Berry's band together and also in the Juggernaut, Nat Pierce/Frank Capp band together. I love Snooky. My three favorite lead trumpet players in the world are Snooky, Al Porcino and Conrad Gozzo. Anybody that's going to learn to play lead trumpet better study those three guys because everybody else comes from those three.

MR: All right.

BS: Anyway thank you so much.

MR: Thank you very much.